



Strike force: Kai Havertz, Bukayo Saka and Martin Odegaard (front to back) all scored as Arsenal thrashed newly promoted Coventry City. REUTERS

BIG WINS AND EARLY SHOCKS

Arsenal and Barcelona make strong starts, but several European heavyweights are left searching for answers after an **unpredictable** opening weekend.

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The unpredictability seen at the FIFA World Cup 2026 has found its way back into club football as the Premier League kicked off its 35th edition. Giants were slain, newcomers announced themselves, and Tottenham Hotspur has somehow gotten worse after spending upwards of 300 million pounds.

Perhaps the only common thread is that Arsenal is the team to beat. The title holder kicked its campaign off in style with a comfortable 3-0 win against newly promoted Coventry City. New signing Christos Tzolis helped set up two of those goals as Kai Havertz, Bukayo Saka and Martin Odegaard found the back of the net to hand Frank Lampard's side a bruising welcome back to the Premier League.

But fortune favoured the other two new faces — Hull City and Ipswich Town — with the former securing the biggest result of the opening matchday. The Tigers handed Manchester United a mauling at home to secure their first-ever top-flight victory against

the record-winner. Michael Carrick may have walked into the MKM Stadium with optimism for his debut as permanent manager, but his side was undone by two first-half set pieces, with Semi Ajayi and Nobel Mendy converting the chances.

Meanwhile, a spirited Ipswich marked its return with a 2-1 win against Sunderland, thanks to former Black Cats' Jack Clarke's 90th-minute winner.

But United's was not the only upset of the opening weekend. Europa League winner Aston Villa was handed a surprise thrashing by Brighton and Hove Albion, which was 4-0 up by the 31st minute, with Jack Hinshelwood grabbing a brace. Elsewhere, Tottenham's alarm bells